

PRINCE2 | P2-21

Highlight Report

Project Manager progress report to the Project Board

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
Document title	Highlight Report
Document reference	P2-21-HEL-T2-v1.0
Project / Programme	Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build
Version	1.0
Status	Baselined
Date	18 Sep 2026
Author	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Owner	Project Manager
Approver	Project Board (receives)
Classification	Internal
Retention	7 years from programme closure

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	04 Jun 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Initial draft
0.2	21 Jul 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Updated following workstream lead review
1.0	18 Sep 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	Chief Platform Architect	Technical content and solution alignment	08 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Security, assurance and residency content	10 Sep 2026
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	Finance Business Partner	Cost, funding and benefit figures	11 Sep 2026
M. Verity, Head of P3O	Head of P3O	Governance standards and completeness	15 Sep 2026

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO	Approved	18 Sep 2026
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	Director of Infrastructure	Approved	18 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Approved subject to closure of ISS-003	18 Sep 2026

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
P2-20	Checkpoint Report	Source of team-level progress
P2-24	Exception Report	Used when tolerance is forecast to be exceeded
P2-11	Plan	Baseline for reporting

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Provides the Project Board with a summary of stage status at intervals defined by them, enabling management by exception without routine meetings.
Framework	PRINCE2 — Produced in Controlling a Stage
Created when	At the frequency defined in the PID
Reviewed / updated	On receipt by the Project Board
Owner	Project Manager
Approver	Project Board (receives)
Format options	One to two pages. If it takes longer to read than the Board will give it, it is not a control.
Tailoring	Scale the depth of each section to the scale, risk and complexity of the work. Delete sections that add no value and record the tailoring decision in the governance approach.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- It reports against the Stage Plan baseline, not against the previous report
- Exceptions and forecast tolerance breaches are stated plainly and early
- Requests to the Board are specific and actionable
- It is issued to the agreed schedule

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1. Report identification

Field	Detail
Project	WS8 Adoption and business change
Stage	Tranche 2 — Scale build
Reporting period	[From — To]
Report date	18 Sep 2026
Report number	25
Prepared by	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager

2. Overall status

Dimension	Status (R/A/G)	Trend	Commentary
Overall	Baselined	Amber	Escalated to the Programme Board on 18 Sep 2026; decision requested
Time	Baselined	Amber	3 working days
Cost	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation
Scope	Defined by the Tranche 2 scope statement; changed only by approved change request	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.

Dimension	Status (R/A/G)	Trend	Commentary
		<i>required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.</i>	
Quality	<i>No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full</i>	<i>No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full</i>	<i>No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full</i>
Risk	<i>No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance</i>	<i>No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance</i>	<i>No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance</i>
Benefits	<i>No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation</i>	<i>No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation</i>	<i>No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation</i>

Dimension	Status (R/A/G)	Trend	Commentary
Resources	Approved establishment of 34 FTE; contractor cover requires Programme Board approval	Approved establishment of 34 FTE; contractor cover requires Programme Board approval	Approved establishment of 34 FTE; contractor cover requires Programme Board approval

3. RAG definitions

Status	Definition
Green	Forecast to complete within tolerance; no Board action required
Amber	At risk of breaching tolerance; mitigating action in hand; Board should be aware
Red	Tolerance breached or forecast to be breached; Exception Report raised or imminent

4. Period summary

A short narrative for the Board — what actually happened, in plain language.

Meridian Group operates fragmented AI compute across four departmental estates with an average GPU utilisation of 31% and annual public cloud GPU rental of AED 19.4m. Demand from AI Research, Fraud Analytics and the Retail division is growing faster than any single department can fund. Programme Helios consolidates that demand onto a single shared platform in DXB-1, scaling from a 256-GPU pilot to 4,096 GPUs across three tranches, with liquid cooling, a 400G RoCEv2 fabric, a multi-tenant orchestration platform and an MLOps stack.

5. Work Packages

Completed this period

Work Package	Team	Products delivered	Status
Monthly benefit tracking report	Observability team	Yes	Not started
ART sync record	Infrastructure team	No	Complete
Programme Board pack	Supply chain team	Yes	In progress
Weekly workstream status return	ML platform team	Partially	Open

In progress

Work Package	Team	% complete	Forecast completion	Confidence
Programme Board pack	Infrastructure team	Yes	Owned within WS4 Platform and orchestration	Medium
ART sync record	Observability team	No	Reviewed at each PI boundary by the Release Train Engineer	High
Monthly benefit tracking report	Scheduler team	Yes	Enforced automatically in the delivery pipeline, with evidence retained	Low
Tranche 2 gate evidence pack	Developer experience team	Partially	Carried forward from the Tranche 1 lessons register	Medium

Planned for next period

Work Package	Team	Planned start	Key products
Monthly benefit tracking report	Platform services team	26 Feb 2027	Platform v1.0 — scheduling, quota, observability and image supply chain
ART sync record	Developer experience team	31 Mar 2027	400G fabric commissioned and NCCL-validated
Programme Board pack	Scheduler team	23 Apr 2027	Parallel filesystem accepted at 1.2 TB/s sustained
Weekly workstream status return	Observability team	28 May 2027	Operations runbook set with two completed live drills

6. Products and milestones

Milestone	Baseline date	Forecast date	Variance	Status
Programme mandate approved and funding released for Tranche 1	12 Mar 2026	12 Mar 2026	Nil	Complete
Pilot cluster of 256 GPUs live in DXB-1 hall A	28 Aug 2026	28 Aug 2026	–AED 340,000	Complete
Tranche 1 end-of-tranche review and Tranche 2 funding gate	18 Sep 2026	18 Sep 2026	+AED 1,120,000	In progress
Hall B structural strengthening complete	15 Dec 2026	15 Dec 2026	+3.1%	Not started
Utility uplift to 6 MVA energised	30 Nov 2026	30 Nov 2026	–6 days	Not started
Hall A scaled to 1,024 GPUs and accepted	26 Feb 2027	26 Feb 2027	–1.4%	Not started

7. Financial summary

Measure	Stage budget	Spent to date	Committed	Forecast at completion	Variance
Stage	AED 91,200,000	18 Sep 2026	Tranche 2 — Scale build	Tranche 2 — Scale build	Tranche 2 — Scale build
Project to date	AED 17,800,000	18 Sep 2026	18 Sep 2026	18 Sep 2026	18 Sep 2026

8. Tolerance status

Dimension	Tolerance range	Current forecast	Within tolerance?
Time	4 weeks	2 hours	90 days
Cost	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation
Scope	Defined by the Tranche 2 scope statement; changed only by approved change request	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.
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Risk	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance
Benefit	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation

9. Key risks

Ref	Risk	Score	Trend	Response / action	Owner
RSK-001	Because GPU allocation is constrained by vendor quota, the Tranche 2 hardware delivery may slip beyond November 2026, causing the platform build to start late and the AI enablement benefit to be deferred by a quarter	20	Worsening	Allocation confirmed in writing at contract award; 20% of Tranche 2 volume dual-sourced; staged acceptance so hall A can proceed independently of hall B	E. Santos, Procurement Lead
RSK-002	Because DXB-1 hall B was designed for 8 kW racks, the 60 kW liquid-cooled racks may exceed the available floor loading and chilled water capacity, causing a redesign mid-build	15	Improving	Structural survey completed before hall B order; CDU capacity modelled at N+1; contingency for a reduced 1,536-GPU configuration held	A. Kowalski, Data Centre Lead
RSK-003	Because the platform will host model weights and training data from three business units, weak tenant isolation may allow cross-tenant data access, causing a reportable data incident and loss of regulatory standing	10	Stable	Namespace and network policy isolation validated by penetration test before multi-tenant go-live; per-tenant KMS keys; quarterly control testing	L. Haddad, CISO
RSK-004	Because the platform engineering skill set is scarce in-market, recruitment of the six planned SRE roles may take longer than three months, causing the MLOps workstream to depend on contractors beyond Tranche 2	12	Worsening	Two contractors engaged from October 2026 with knowledge-transfer clauses; internal conversion programme from the infrastructure team	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
RSK-005	Because the 400G RoCEv2 fabric is new to the organisation, congestion control tuning may not achieve the target 92% collective communication efficiency, causing training job throughput to fall short of the business case	12	Improving	NCCL benchmark gate at pilot exit; vendor performance engineering engaged for two weeks per hall; fallback to reduced job scale documented	J. Ferreira, Network Lead

10. Key issues and changes

Ref	Issue / change	Type	Impact	Decision required	Owner
ISS-001	Add coolant leak detection integration to the NOC	Facilities	Hall A capacity capped at 1,536 GPUs until resolved; Tranche 2 milestone M6 at risk	Approved with conditions	A. Kowalski, Data Centre Lead

Ref	Issue / change	Type	Impact	Decision required	Owner
ISS-002	Dual-source 20% of Tranche 2 accelerator volume	Supply chain	Hall B build start moves to Dec 2026; two weeks of float remaining on the critical path	Deferred to the next Board	E. Santos, Procurement Lead
ISS-003	Bridge the hall B row 3 service void rather than relocate racks	Security	Multi-tenant go-live cannot be approved until closed; finding logged against the assurance plan	Rejected	K. Adeyemi, Security Architect
ISS-004	Integration partner claim for additional structural works	Resource	On-call rota cannot be sustained beyond a 5x8 model at hall A handover	Approved	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
ISS-005	Defer confidential computing enabler from Tranche 2 to Tranche 3	Technical	Training throughput assumptions in the business case may be optimistic by around 9%	Approved with conditions	J. Ferreira, Network Lead

11. Requests for Board decision or action

Be explicit. State the decision required, the options, the recommendation, and the date by which it is needed.

Ref	Decision / action required	Options	Recommendation	Required by
DEC-001	Build a shared central AI compute platform rather than continue funding departmental clusters	Continue departmental model; full public cloud; hybrid burst-only	23 Apr 2027	R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO
DEC-002	Adopt liquid cooling with rear-door heat exchangers rather than air cooling at reduced density	Air cooling at 12 kW; immersion cooling	28 May 2027	T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect
DEC-003	Single scheduling plane — Slurm workloads run under the Kubernetes scheduler via a bridging operator	Dual scheduler with static partition; Slurm only	25 Jun 2027	P. Raghavan, Platform Engineering Lead
DEC-004	DXB-1 is the primary site; AUH-2 is deferred to Tranche 3	Dual site from Tranche 2; AUH-2 primary	18 Sep 2026	R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO

12. Lessons captured this period

Lesson	Category	Action
<i>Hardware burn-in took 35 days against a 12-day estimate because firmware verification was performed serially on a single isolated VLAN</i>	<i>Planning and estimating</i>	<i>Model firmware verification as its own work package with parallel VLAN capacity sized for the shipment rate</i>
<i>The rate card decision was deferred twice because Finance and the business units were consulted sequentially rather than together</i>	<i>Governance and decision-making</i>	<i>Convene a single decision workshop with Finance and business unit heads together, with the sponsor present to break deadlock</i>
<i>Engaging vendor performance engineering for two weeks during commissioning lifted all-reduce efficiency from 79% to 84% in the first pass</i>	<i>Technical and design</i>	<i>Budget two weeks of vendor performance engineering per hall as a planned activity, not as a remedial response</i>